Seranai

OpenFOS

Open Founder Operating System

Business Model & Unit Economics

24 Skills + 2 Reference Modules
Organized by FOUNDRY Framework

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What Is This Skill?

The Business Model & Unit Economics skill is an AI-powered tool that helps you answer the question every investor, co-founder, and honest advisor will eventually ask: Is this business fundamentally profitable?

It works in two tightly connected phases. In Phase 3, you design your revenue model, choosing how you charge, how much you charge, and how you distribute your product. In Phase 4, you calculate the unit economics: the five core metrics that determine whether your model makes money at scale, or quietly loses it.

No spreadsheets. No finance jargon. No guesswork. You describe your product and customers, and the skill walks you through every calculation step by step showing you the formula, the number, and what it means.

THE CORE PRINCIPLE

Every number in your unit economics model must come from you or from a source you have reviewed and approved. The skill never assumes.

That's what makes the output investor-grade.

By the end of one conversation (~25 minutes), you will have a confirmed revenue model, a fully calculated unit economics dashboard, a three-scenario stress test, and a clear verdict on your model's health — with a ranked list of what to fix if the numbers are not where they need to be.

Who Is This For?

This skill is designed for founders who have validated their problem, sized their market, identified their beachhead, defined their persona, and built their value proposition and are now ready to answer the hardest commercial question: Does this model make money? It is especially useful if:

- You have a value proposition and want to know if customers will pay enough to make the economics work
- You are preparing for investor conversations and need to defend your unit economics with real numbers
- You are pre-launch and want to stress-test your assumptions before you spend on growth
- You have early revenue but suspect your margins or retention are not healthy enough to scale
- You have never built a financial model before and need a structured, conversational way to think through the numbers
- You want to know the single most important lever to pull to make your model stronger

This skill works for any B2B business model: SaaS, transactional, usage-based, marketplace, and more. Whether you are in Mumbai, Nairobi, London, or São Paulo, the framework adapts to your currency, customer type, and market context.

How to Get Started

Using this skill requires three things: access to Claude (claude.ai or the Claude app), the Business Model & Unit Economics skill installed, and your idea described in your own words.

Step 1: Open Claude and Start a New Conversation

Go to claude.ai or open the Claude app. Start a new conversation. That's it.

Step 2: Describe Your Idea

Tell Claude what your product does, who your customer is, and if you have one a rough idea of how you want to charge. You do not need perfect numbers to start. The skill will ask for anything that's missing and help you derive numbers you don't yet have.

Examples of Great Starting Messages:

EXAMPLE 1: With Pricing in Mind

"I'm building an HR compliance tool for SMBs in India. My customers are HR managers at companies with 50–200 employees. I'm thinking of charging ₹3,000/month per company. I spend about ₹80,000/month on sales and marketing and typically close 6–8 new customers."

EXAMPLE 2: With Prior Skill Outputs

"I've already completed my Value Proposition Canvas. My product automates invoice reconciliation for logistics companies. I charge ₹15,000/month. My gross margin is around 70% and I expect about 5% monthly churn."

EXAMPLE 3: Minimal

"Payroll software for small businesses in Southeast Asia. I haven't decided on pricing yet."

All three will work. The more you share upfront, the faster you'll reach your first output. But even a single sentence is enough the skill will only ask for what is genuinely missing.

Step 3: Follow the Conversation

The skill guides you through two phases. You do not need to prepare anything in advance or remember any steps. Just respond naturally to the questions it asks. The whole process takes about 25 minutes.

What Happens: The Two Phases

The skill walks you through two phases, each building directly on the last. Here's what to expect at each stage.

PHASE 3: BUSINESS MODEL DESIGN *Revenue model, pricing & distribution • ~10 minutes*	
What You Do	• Confirm what your product does and who your customer is • Share how you are currently thinking about charging (rough is fine) • Describe how you plan to sell, self-serve, sales team, or partnerships • Review 3-4 shortlisted revenue models filtered to your specific business • Choose your model and confirm your pricing structure
What You Get	• A Revenue Model Shortlist: 3-4 options filtered to your product and customer, each with trade-offs • A Pricing Analysis comparing cost-plus, value-based, and competitive anchoring approaches • Your recommended price with the rationale behind it • A Business Model Summary Card covering your model, distribution motion, revenue levers, and top risks • A clear model verdict: Viable / Viable with caveats / Needs rework

PHASE 4: UNIT ECONOMICS *Five core metrics that determine profitability • ~15 minutes*	
What You Do	• Provide your pricing (ARPU or ACV) • Estimate your direct delivery cost per customer per month • Share your sales and marketing spend and the customers it typically generates • Estimate your monthly churn rate or average customer lifespan • Confirm or approve any benchmarks used to fill gaps
What You Get	• A full Unit Economics Dashboard: Gross Margin, CAC, LTV, LTV:CAC Ratio, and Payback Period, each shown with the formula and number • A three-scenario Stress Test (Bear / Base / Bull) showing how sensitive your model is to changes in churn, CAC, and ARPU

	• A Fix Priority List if your model is Marginal or Broken — ranked by impact, not effort • A Unit Economics Summary Card with your overall health status and investor readiness signal • A Day 1 Metrics Tracking List if you are pre-launch, so you know exactly what to measure from your first customer

Understanding Your Results

The Seven Revenue Models

The skill does not ask you to pick a model from a list. It filters the options based on your product and customer typically presenting 3-4 candidates and recommends the best fit. Here are all seven models it works with:

Revenue Model	Best When…	Key Metric to Watch
Monthly Subscription (SaaS)	Product is used continuously and delivers recurring value	Monthly churn rate
Annual Contract (SaaS)	Customers commit long-term; reduces churn risk for you	Net Revenue Retention
Usage-Based / Pay-per-use	Value scales with how much the customer uses the product	Usage growth per customer
Transactional / Per-deal fee	Product facilitates discrete events (payments, hires, shipments)	Transaction volume
Marketplace / Take rate	Platform connects buyers and sellers; revenue is a % of GMV	Gross Merchandise Value
Freemium to Paid	Low-friction acquisition; monetise through conversion to paid tiers	Free-to-paid conversion rate
Professional Services / Project	Customisation or implementation is core to delivery	Utilisation rate and project margin

The Three Pricing Approaches

For any model you choose, the skill evaluates three approaches to setting the right price and shows you the number each one produces:

Approach	Formula	Best When…
Cost-Plus Pricing	COGS per customer × (1 + target margin %)	You need to protect minimum margin and your costs are well-understood
Value-Based Pricing	% of measurable value (time saved, cost reduced) you deliver to the customer	Your product has a provable ROI you can quantify in the customer's own terms

Competitive Anchoring	Position relative to the market range established by comparable products	Customers will benchmark you against existing alternatives they already know

The Five Core Unit Economics Metrics

These are the five numbers that determine whether your business is fundamentally profitable. The skill calculates all five and shows every formula step by step.

Metric	What It Measures	Benchmark
Gross Margin %	Revenue remaining after direct delivery costs, the foundation of all other metrics	60-80% SaaS | 30-50% marketplace | 20-40% services
CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost)	What you spend on sales and marketing to win one paying customer	Varies by model what matters is LTV:CAC ratio
LTV (Lifetime Value)	Total revenue one customer generates before they cancel, net of delivery cost	Should be at least 3× CAC for a healthy model
LTV:CAC Ratio	The fundamental profitability signal how much you recover for every unit spent acquiring a customer	3:1 or higher is the investor sweet spot
Payback Period	Months to recover your CAC from gross profit determines how much cash growth consumes	<12 months (SaaS) | <6 months (transactional)

Reading Your LTV:CAC Ratio

The LTV:CAC ratio is the single most watched number in B2B unit economics. Here is how to interpret yours:

🔴 **< 1:1 • Broken**
You spend more acquiring a customer than you recover. Do not scale.

🟡 **1:1 – 3:1 • Marginal**
Revenue covers acquisition but leaves little room for overhead or growth.

🟢 **3:1 – 10:1 • Healthy**
The investor sweet spot. Profitable to acquire and scale.

⚠️ **10:1+ • Over-conservative**
Under-investing in growth. You could be acquiring more customers with this margin.

Reading the Scenario Stress Test

The skill never leaves you with a single projection. After calculating your base case, it runs three scenarios to show how sensitive your model is to realistic changes in the key inputs:

Scenario	What Changes	What It Tells You
🐻 Bear Case	Churn increases by 2%, CAC rises 50%, ARPU drops 20%	How bad can it get if things go wrong? Can the business survive its worst realistic case?
📊 Base Case	Your confirmed inputs, no adjustments	The model as it stands today, with your actual assumptions
🐂 Bull Case	Churn falls by 1%, CAC drops 30%, ARPU rises 20%	What does the upside look like if execution goes well? Is it worth pursuing?

THE KEY INSIGHT FROM THE STRESS TEST
The stress test tells you which variable your model is most sensitive to.
If churn moves your LTV:CAC the most, reducing churn is your #1 priority.
If CAC moves it most, your acquisition efficiency is the lever to pull.
The fix list always targets the highest-impact variable first — not the easiest one.

Tips for Getting the Most Out of This Skill

Use rough numbers, the skill is built for them.

“About ₹2,500/month” and “maybe 5% churn” are enough to start. The skill will show you how small changes in your estimates affect the output and flag which assumptions matter most.

“I don’t know” is a valid input.

If you don’t know your churn, the skill will suggest a benchmark and ask if it sounds right. If you don’t know your CAC, it will help you derive it from your spend and conversion. Uncertainty is data, it tells you what to measure next.

Always complete Phase 3 before Phase 4.

The unit economics model only makes sense once the revenue model is locked. Skipping to the numbers before confirming how you charge and what your delivery costs are produces projections that won’t survive investor scrutiny.

Run it for different pricing tiers.

If you are considering a ₹1,500/month plan vs. a ₹3,500/month plan, run the unit economics for each. The difference in payback period and LTV:CAC often makes the decision obvious.

Show the formula, not just the number.

Investors do not just want to see “LTV:CAC = 4.2.” They want to see: ARPU × margin × lifespan ÷ CAC = 4.2. The skill outputs the full calculation, keep it in when you present.

Broken unit economics are fixable.

Most founders discover their initial unit economics are rough. That is the point of this exercise. The Fix Priority List tells you exactly what to change and what the effect will be so you can fix the model before you spend on growth.

Come back as your data improves.

Unit economics built on projections should be rerun at 10 customers, 30 customers, and 100 customers. A model that evolves with real data is a sign of a rigorous founder and a much stronger investor conversation.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need to have completed the earlier skills first?
Not strictly. But the business model is much sharper when it is built on top of a validated problem (Skill 1), a defined persona (Skill 4), and a confirmed value proposition (Skill 5). If those outputs are in the conversation, the skill pulls them in automatically. If they are not, it will either run those steps inline or flag the gap and proceed with what you have.

What if I don’t have any revenue data yet?
That is fine and common. The skill runs the full model on projected inputs and labels every number clearly as an assumption. It then generates a Day 1 Metrics Tracking List, the exact numbers to capture from your first customer so you can refine the model with real data as early as possible.

What if my LTV:CAC comes out below 1:1?
The skill will not sugarcoat it. A ratio below 1:1 means you are currently spending more to acquire a customer than you will ever recover and the skill will say so directly. But it will also run the Fix Priority List to show you which lever (churn, CAC, or ARPU) has the most impact, so you know exactly what to change before spending on growth.

How is this different from building a financial model in Excel?
A spreadsheet gives you numbers. This skill gives you numbers plus interpretation, industry benchmarks, scenario analysis, and a ranked list of what to fix. It also asks the right questions in the right order, something a blank spreadsheet does not do. The output is also formatted to explain to investors, not just to yourself.

Can I use this for a marketplace or transactional model, not just SaaS?

Yes. The skill works across all B2B revenue model types: subscription, usage-based, transactional, marketplace, and professional services. The formulas adjust to the model. For marketplace businesses, for example, LTV is calculated on net revenue (take rate × GMV), not gross transaction value.

Can I ask for investor-ready projections?

Yes, but with a caveat. If you have fewer than 3 months of real data, the skill will build projections from assumptions and label them clearly. Investor-grade projections require at least some real numbers: real churn, real CAC, real ARPU. The skill will tell you which assumptions to replace with data first.

How long does it take?

About 25 minutes for the full Phase 3 + Phase 4 conversation. Faster if you have already completed your Value Proposition Canvas and have rough pricing and cost estimates ready. Longer if you need to work through the revenue model choice in detail or if several inputs require derivation.

The FOUNDRY Framework

FOUNDRY is the sequential journey framework that guides founders from initial idea through scale or exit. Each letter represents a stage, and each stage contains specific skills a founder needs to master.

Stage	Purpose	Skills
F – Foundation	Validate the idea. Confirm the problem is real, the market exists, and you know who to serve.	Skills 1–4
O – Outline	Design the business. Articulate value, map competition, model revenue, scope the MVP.	Skills 5–8
U – User	Acquire and understand customers. Discover needs, design GTM, set pricing, run experiments.	Skills 9–12
N – Nurture	Build relationships and traction. Craft the pitch, model financials, build the founder narrative.	Skills 13–15
D – Discipline	Execute and operate. Set OKRs, hire the team, handle legal and entity setup.	Skills 16–18
R – Results	Measure and iterate. Track KPIs, assess PMF, decide whether to pivot or persevere.	Skills 19–20
Y – Yield	Scale or exit. Confirm scaling readiness, plan liquidity events.	Skills 21–22

Cross-cutting skills (23–24) are not stage-specific and can be invoked at any point in the journey. Reference modules (R1–R2) are shared evaluation lenses that multiple skills invoke. They are never used in isolation.

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